



“Like a tagline for a corporate brand, [Rajini] has a punchline, which appeals even to kids... usually a one-liner refreshed for every film”

KANDASWAMY BHARATHAN
JOINT MANAGING DIRECTOR,
KAVITHALAYAA PRODUCTIONS



“Suppose a film of his is made for ₹150 crore, it will surely earn at least ₹200 crore at the box office. The producer, distributor, and theatre owners are happy”

ABIRAMI RAMANATHAN
DIRECTOR-PRODUCER-EXHIBITOR

a Japanese couple travelled to India to watch *Jailer*, while a video clip of Japan's Ambassador to India, Hiroshi Suzuki, dancing to the film's song went viral. *Muthu* and *Enthiran* are now both case studies at IIM Ahmedabad and ISB.

Yet another marketing strategy at play is of brand scarcity—whether it is Rajini's deliberate ploy to space out films after *Baashha* and *Muthu* for lack of strong scripts (between 2000 and 2010, he had only three releases); or his policy of never appearing in commercials in his five-decade-long career, except in a couple for charitable causes like eye donation.

Krissna says Rajini's brand is that you have to come and watch the man on the big screen in his movies. “He never believed in being on TV every day. People still always wait for his films.” It's a trend that top Tamil actors follow to this day, though they appeared in commercials earlier. “Only actors much lower in the rung sign up for commercials here,” says Pillai. Contrast this to the North, where Shah Rukh Khan and Amitabh Bachchan are among the top endorsers today. Senthil Kumar, Chief Creative Officer at Wunder-

man Thompson South Asia, says Rajini can easily charge premiums higher than Amitabh Bachchan or even Virat Kohli should he choose to do an ad today. “He has not missed out on anything. Advertising has probably missed out on him.”

Over the years, younger actors across Indian film industries have surpassed Rajini's salary as eye-watering star fees are the order of the day. The competition in Tamil Nadu, at least, is between Rajini, Vijay and Ajith. The three fluctuate within a difference of ₹5-10 crore in terms of the sum distributors are willing to pay for their films. Much younger Telugu stars such as Prabhas and Allu Arjun have also seen their fees skyrocket in the wake of Telugu films' pan-India box office successes recently. Further afar, Bollywood stars Shah Rukh Khan, Salman Khan, Aamir Khan and Akshay Kumar have been taking home hefty payments for several years now. Still, Rajini is peerless in his age bracket. His contemporaries such as Amitabh Bachchan, Mammooty, Mohanlal and Chiranjeevi are paid far lesser.

“When someone other than him delivers an industry hit at age 72, we can talk about threats,” says GK Cinemas' Mathivanan. It is industry speak for the film with the highest collection in its home box office. Mathivanan points out that it took a *Baahubali 2* to beat *Enthiran*'s ‘industry hit’ tag. “Rajini was at the top for those six-seven years. Again, he is at the top now.” Rajini has already got two to three films in the works. One of them, also produced by Sun Pictures, will be helmed by Lokesh Kanagaraj, who directed Kamal Hassan's successful *Vikram*. Noting that the film will be out by the time the actor is 75 and that his brand value will remain intact, Pillai quips: “He is a superstar for life.”

As curtains fall on the era of the demigod big-screen idol in a digital world where content is king, Rajini just may be the last of his kind. **BT**

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